

MANDAR DEODHAR

HOMES

SANDEEP NALGE, 38
Senior manager with a leading private sector bank

RAJASHRI NALGE, 37
Advocate

Navi Mumbai

What they bought: **A 1,400 sq. ft 2BHK flat in Nerul, Navi Mumbai, in Dec. 2023**

Cost: **₹1.5 crore**

Nalge was on the lookout for a flat bigger than the one they owned in Kamote, another residential hub in Navi Mumbai. The reputation of the builder mattered to him, as did the amenities, which included a walking track on the terrace of the 18-storey tower, a swimming pool and lift parking for cars. "With the airport coming up near Panvel, the cost of property has risen by 30 per cent in two years. It will rise further, so we thought we'd invest now," he says. Nalge sold off their Kamote flat to make the initial down payment of 50 per cent of the cost of the flat, and plans to take a home loan for the remaining amount. Being a bank employee, he gets a 2.5 per cent discount on home loan rates.

of easy financing options from fintech and non-banking finance companies such as Bajaj Finance and Kotak. Partnerships with them help companies offer zero-interest EMI schemes and credit card offers, enabling consumers to buy higher technology and better capacity products. "At the industry level," Nandi confirms, "approximately 40 per cent of the big-ticket items like ACs, refrigerators and top-load washing machines are being sold through finance."

SMARTPHONES: RINGING ENDORSEMENT

It is a curious psychology that makes one want to own an expensive smartphone and so the category merits individual attention. Many would say it is need, not indulgence that dictates their choice. That was true for 23-year-old Mumbai resident Meera Kamath, in the final year of her master's in film direction. Last April, she persuaded her father to buy her an iPhone 14 Plus worth more than Rs 80,000 through six-month instalments at zero interest. "As students in a film school," she says, "we need to do shoots for projects that include documentaries and short films. Hiring a film camera becomes expensive for students like us, but most of these can be shot by a higher-end phone that provides good clarity."

The numbers speak for the trend. Although the Indian smartphone market remained flat in 2023 (Jan.-Oct.), with an overall shipment size of 44 million, the sale of premium smartphones (priced at Rs 50,000-Rs 70,000) has grown 52 per cent over the previous year. The iPhone 13/14, Galaxy S23/S23 FE and the Moto Razr 40 mostly drove the sales. The mid-premium (Rs 33,000-Rs 50,000) segment grew 37 per cent year-on-year and had a five per cent share of the overall smartphone market. The mass budget segment (Rs 8,000-Rs 16,000), on the other hand, commanding a 44 per cent share of the overall smartphones market, declined by 14 per cent year-on-year.

As the trend of premiumisation grows, Android phonemakers are upping their game too, with Samsung, Xiaomi and Oppo promising four years of Android updates and another year of security updates instead of the standard two-version upgrade. This is because premium smartphone users tend to use their devices for 40-44 months, compared to 36 months for users of budget smartphones.

REAL ESTATE: TALL ASPIRATIONS

After a long winter, real estate fortunes finally seem to be turning. Covid brought home the value of large, amenities-rich residences, which is why preference for that bracket is a significant part of the post-pandemic bounce-back. According to a report by property consultancy Knight Frank, eight major markets—Mumbai, the National Capital Region, Bengaluru, Hyderabad, Pune, Ahmedabad, Kolkata and Chennai—saw demand for homes move up to 82,612 units in the third quarter of calendar year 2023, 12 per cent higher than the year-ago period. The share of upper segment homes (Rs 1 crore upwards) rose to 35 per cent of overall